

AgroParisTech Action Plan in the context of the CoARA Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment

Preamble

AgroParisTech has signed the Coara agreement on the 3rd of January 2023. The signature of this agreement fits perfectly with the values of the institution by recognizing the diversity of the contributions to research, by banning inappropriate uses of quantitative indicators and by relying on qualitative evaluation for research quality assessment. This signature is also in line with the involvement of AgroParisTech for many years in Open science with its own policy and with the guidance it produced relative to ethics in research.

The aim of the present document is to share with the signatories of the CoARA agreement, and within AgroParisTech community as well, how AgroParisTech has started the process of developing processes in line with the core commitments and to communicate its Action Plan with defined milestones.

Research assessment at AgroParisTech is performed in the following situations:

- + Providing agreement on: the right to supervise doctoral candidates without a so-called HDR (*Habilitation à diriger des recherches*, the diploma that allows to supervise doctoral candidates in France); research proposals in the context of AgroParisTech calls for projects.
- + Providing opinion on: activities of teacher-researchers to be transmitted to the national body for evaluation of teacher-researchers in the field of agriculture (CNECA); periods for teacher-researchers to allocate more time to research; emerita.
- + The process of recruitment of researchers and teacher-researchers.
- + Individual bonus allocations.

The quality of the research performed at AgroParisTech in relation with its main research partners is also a key element for internal and external communication and for its own evaluation as a higher education and research institution.

The main principles and processes of reforming research at AgroParisTech has been presented and discussed with its scientific council.

What has been done in 2023 and before

- + On all the dossiers for which an agreement or an opinion is required relative to research quality, the assessment by AgroParisTech is based on a narrative presentation of the research, accounted for in all its dimensions (including, for instance Open science). Journal impact factors and ranking of institutions are not taken into account.

- + AgroParisTech has for years refused to provide indicators relative to impact factors for its own activity report to the ministry in charge of providing its resources (the ministry of agriculture and food sovereignty).
- + Training and support are proposed to AgroParisTech research community on publication strategy including Open science, new publication strategies (PCI initiatives for instance), insisting on banning the use of impact factor as a criterion for establishing this publication strategy.
- + Individual bonus allocations and individual evolutions managed by CNECA are based on dossiers presenting all the aspects of the research performed (research activities, presented in a narrative way highlighting the originality and the coherence of the research, doctoral training, ethics, research network and impact of the research for socio-economic partners and the society in general, in link with AgroParisTech policies relative to Open science and science and society);
- + The presidents of AgroParisTech Education and Research Departments have been sensibilized to this revision of research assessment within AgroParisTech.

Action plan for 2024 and beyond

2024

- + Checking all the documents relative to assessing research quality and adding, if necessary, the indication that quantitative metrics such as impact factors or h-index will not be accounted for.
- + Checking that all communication of AgroParisTech relative to rankings is in line with the CoARA agreement.
- + Raising awareness of research assessment at AgroParisTech *via* internal communications with a particular focus on all new researchers at AgroParisTech (a date has been identified: the 30th of January 2024), trainings on ethics and scientific integrity.
- + Developing tools such as narrative-CV adapted to the context and expectations of AgroParisTech (an internal working group would be constituted).
- + Joining the initiative about CoARA French chapter <https://hal.science/hal-04264538v1>

2025

- + Finalizing the narrative-CV adapted to the context and expectations of AgroParisTech.
- + Developing indicators to assess potential unconscious bias in research assessment, for instance between disciplines or relative to interdisciplinary researches.
- + Encouraging the involvement of AgroParisTech researchers in research assessment for other institutions.
- + Proposing a training on research assessment and its reform at different scales to AgroParisTech students and doctoral candidates.
- + Assessment by the scientific council of the application of CoARA agreement by AgroParisTech.
- + Updating the Action Plan.